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WORLD CUP 2003

India’s preparation for the 2003 World Cup in South Africa and Zimbabwe really started during the tour to New Zealand in December 2002. We lost to the Kiwis in both formats of the game and while those defeats were demoralizing, as defeats always are, they helped the team to focus with just a month to go before the World Cup.

We played two Test matches in New Zealand and lost both. In the first Test at Wellington, which started on 12 December, we were beaten by ten wickets, with the match finishing in just three days. The pitch offered a lot of assistance to the fast bowlers and even Parthiv Patel, our wicketkeeper, was getting the ball to swing prodigiously in the nets.

I played the first Test with an injured finger, which I had hurt during practice. On the first morning, when the rest of the team were on the ground preparing to play, I was in hospital with Andrew Leipus getting my finger checked. The pain was getting severe and I was finding it impossible to catch the ball. Even when a fielder gently tossed the ball to me to pass on to the bowler I was having difficulty catching it. Batting was not so much of a problem, as I could grip the bat as normal, but fielding was a real issue. I asked the doctor to numb my finger, but he refused, saying I would have no idea where my finger was and might break it if I didn’t catch the ball properly. All I could do was put up with the pain.

When I got back to the ground, I went up to captain Sourav Ganguly and suggested I should field at short leg. In that position, the ball would either lob to me or, if it was a firm hit, I would receive the blow on my body instead of attempting to catch it. Both of these possibilities were